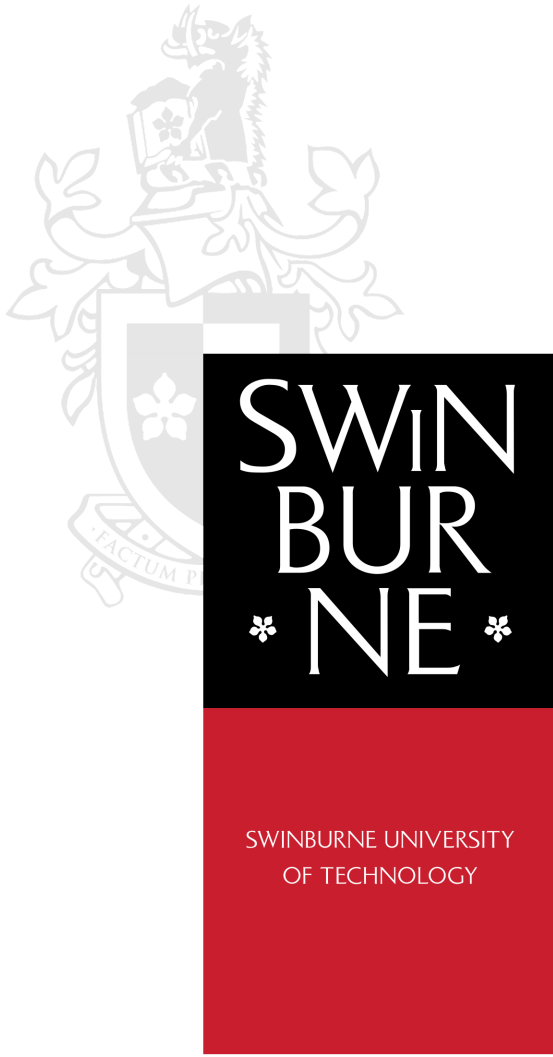




"APOLLO'S GAMBLE" GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

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ART10004 - Introduction to Game Studies
Assignment 3 - Game Design Document

Voted #1 highest marked assignment



APOLLO'S GAMBLE

A Card Game of Battle and Prophecy

2-6 

10+ 

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Main Concept

Pitch of Game

The setting is Ancient Greece, and Apollo is searching for a new prophet. Having recently lost the previous Oracle of Delphi to a crazed cyclops rampage, the sun god calls for seers to step forward and show off their divine skills.

Called Apollo's Gamble, players compete for this esteemed title by attempting to predict the correct outcome of as many events as possible. As heroes venture off into the great unknown, encountering the wars of men, horrifying monstrosities and fulfilling their destinies for a chance of eternal glory, players are given the choice to aid them on their quests; or let them be crushed by the weight of their fate, all for the outcome of having the correct prediction.

Distinguishing Features

Separating 'Apollo's Gamble' from other card games currently on the market is the presentation and mechanics of the cards themselves. Each card is embellished with unique hand drawn art, displaying proud warriors, fearsome beasts, and iconic weaponry.

A unique mechanic to Apollo's Gamble is the use of success and failure cards; allowing players to make, and stick by, their desired outcome, making it impossible to swap predictions mid-round as their choice is laid down in front of them.

Players are able to manipulate the narrative, changing the events of actual mythology by pairing heroes with monsters they may have never encountered in their lifetime, or with events playing out differently each time depending on players choice.

What we encourage/expect

With their fate in their own hands, players are emboldened to forge their own path, silently playing their hand in an attempt to gather points for themselves, or collaborating with others in an effort to sabotage those further ahead with their predictions and on the verge of winning the game.

For those who enjoy spinning their own tales, the endless narrative choice of how different boons and curses would alter the outcome of their prophecies as the outcome is being finalized, especially as each chosen pairing of heroes and events defies tales originally told in mythology, prompting players to draw their own conclusions as to how it would end.

Inspiration

Games that have aided our vision for Apollo's Gamble are Space Alert (Vlaada Chvátil, 2008) with the ability to dictate the course of the game before the round even starts.

The way Dungeon Mayhem (Wizards of The Coast, 2018) is played, with cards around the table, inspired the removal of a board and the incorporation of a strictly card-based system. Additionally, their "mighty power cards" inspired the curse and boon card system, with the mechanics and effects of those drawing influence from the deck of Cutthroat Caverns (Curt Covert, 2007).

Additionally, the ability to reimagine the tales of Greek mythology was compelling; with such vast stories waiting to be told, the combinations of tales is endless.

Game Mechanics

Game Contents

- A deck of 20 **Hero Cards**
- A deck of 20 **Event Cards**
- A deck of 40 **Boons & Curse Cards**
- 12 Prophecy Cards; 6 **Success** & 6 **Failure**

Game Rules

Game for 2 - 6 Players.

1. At the beginning of the game, give each player one **Success Card** and one **Failure Card**. Then shuffle each of the three decks and place them side by side in the centre of the play area.
2. After the decks are shuffled, hand out THREE **Boons & Curse** cards to each player, either randomly or in clockwise order.
3. Once all players have both their **Success/Failure** cards and their **Boons & Curses**, draw one **Hero Card** and one **Event Card** from the top of each deck and place them face up.
4. Will the Hero succeed or fail? Once the **Hero** and **Event** cards are laid facing up, each player must place either their **Success** or **Failure** card face down in front of them, keeping the other in their hand, to decide their prophecy.

5. Each **Hero** and **Event** card have a FLAT number on them, the aim is for each player to use their **Boons & Curse** cards to raise or lower those numbers to get the outcome they desire.
6. Now go clockwise throughout the group twice, each time placing ONE **Boon & Curse** card below your target (Hero or Event) face down.
7. Once each player has placed TWO **Boon & Curse** cards, it is time to see the outcome. Flip each card face up without changing their order or position and follow their buff, debuff or effect. Once the outcome has been established and the **Hero** has either succeeded or failed, it is time to see the prophecies.
8. Each player will turn over their **Prophecy Cards** and show whether they predicted correctly or not. If a player predicted the outcome correctly they will gain a point, if predicted incorrectly they will not.
9. To reset play for another round, remove the used **Hero** and **Event** card to a graveyard, collect all placed **Boon & Curse** cards, reshuffle them into the deck, and hand out TWO to each player. Place another **Hero** and **Event** card and begin another round.
10. After the chosen game length of **5/7/10/15** rounds, whoever has the most points is the new Oracle. (If throughout the game, any of the decks are exhausted, reshuffle all graveyard cards back into the decks.) If the game ends in a tie, players can either surrender to allow one player to be the victor, or enter **Sudden Death**. Tied victor players will change to **Last Oracle Standing** mode, being knocked out if they predict incorrectly ONCE, until only one player is victorious.

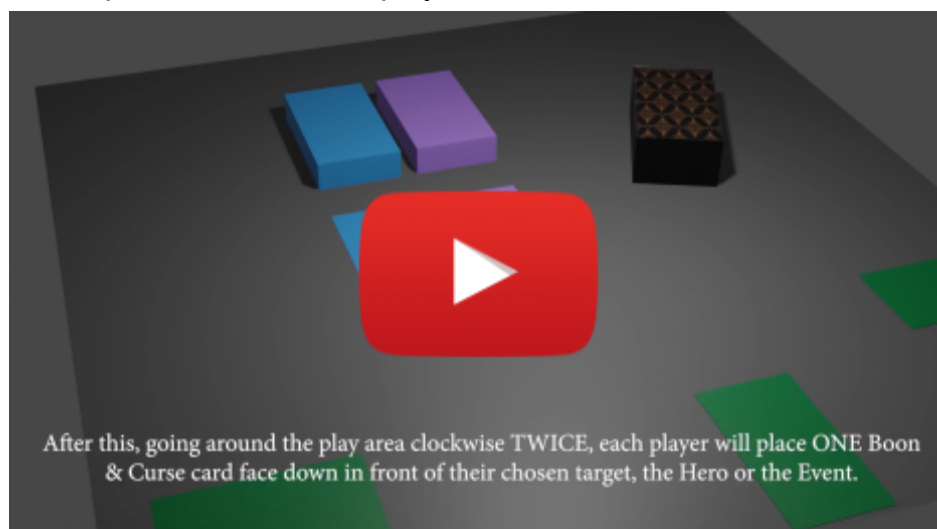
OPTIONAL PLAY MODE - LAST ORACLE STANDING;

An optional game mode available for play is Last Oracle Standing. In this game mode instead of fighting for points, players will combat each other in an endurance game. If a player predicts an outcome incorrectly THREE times, they are removed from play and banished from Delphi, and the game continues until only one Oracle remains.

Boon & Curse Card Effects

Card Type	Card Effect
FLAT number addition/subtraction (15 Cards in Deck)	These cards will only add or subtract from the total number of the target card.
FLAT number multiplication/division (10 Cards in Deck)	These cards will multiply or divide the current FLAT number by TWO. If it is the first card below a target, then the target's beginning FLAT is multiplied/divided. If there are other cards above it, include those in a total FLAT before multiplying/dividing.
Remove Above/Below Card (8 Cards in Deck)	These cards will remove from play the Boon & Curse cards either above or below them (it will state which on the card). They are removed from the target and are not included in the final outcome.
Special Effect Cards (7 Cards in Deck)	These cards will have a two effects, the effect used will depend on the chosen target ie. Card will add 10 to the Hero FLAT number, or multiply the Event FLAT by 2. These are powerful cards that allow players to make quick decisions based on how they think the game is turning.

Below is an example of one round of play;



Player Activity

As 'Apollo's Gamble' has heavy competitive elements (Agon), randomness (Alea), and players being uncertain of each others actions, we would expect the players to act similarly to playing a game of Texas Hold'Em Poker; taking turns around the table attempting to deceive other players of their true intentions while simultaneously attempting to get the upper hand. While the game has set rules regarding the interactions between cards, and therefore is more paidaic, we would also expect a high degree of ludic play, in a similar vein to the multitude of different rules players have created for the ways cards stack and interact in the game 'Uno' (Mattel, 1992). We would also not only expect but encourage the players to come up with new game modes outside of the two predescribed modes that come with the game.

Aesthetic Design

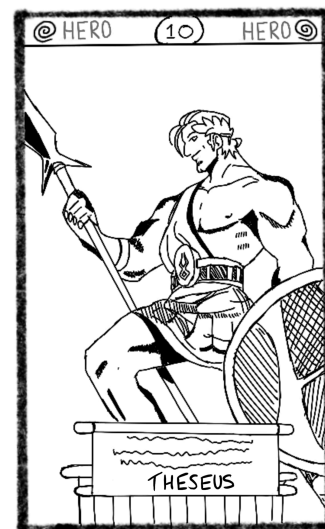
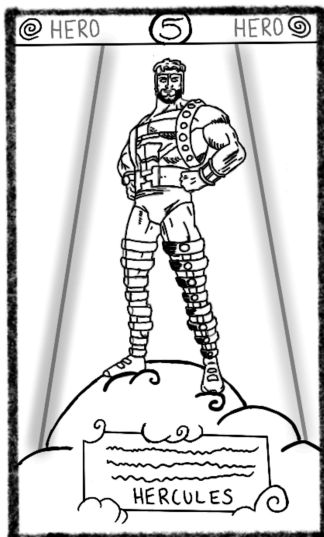
Theme

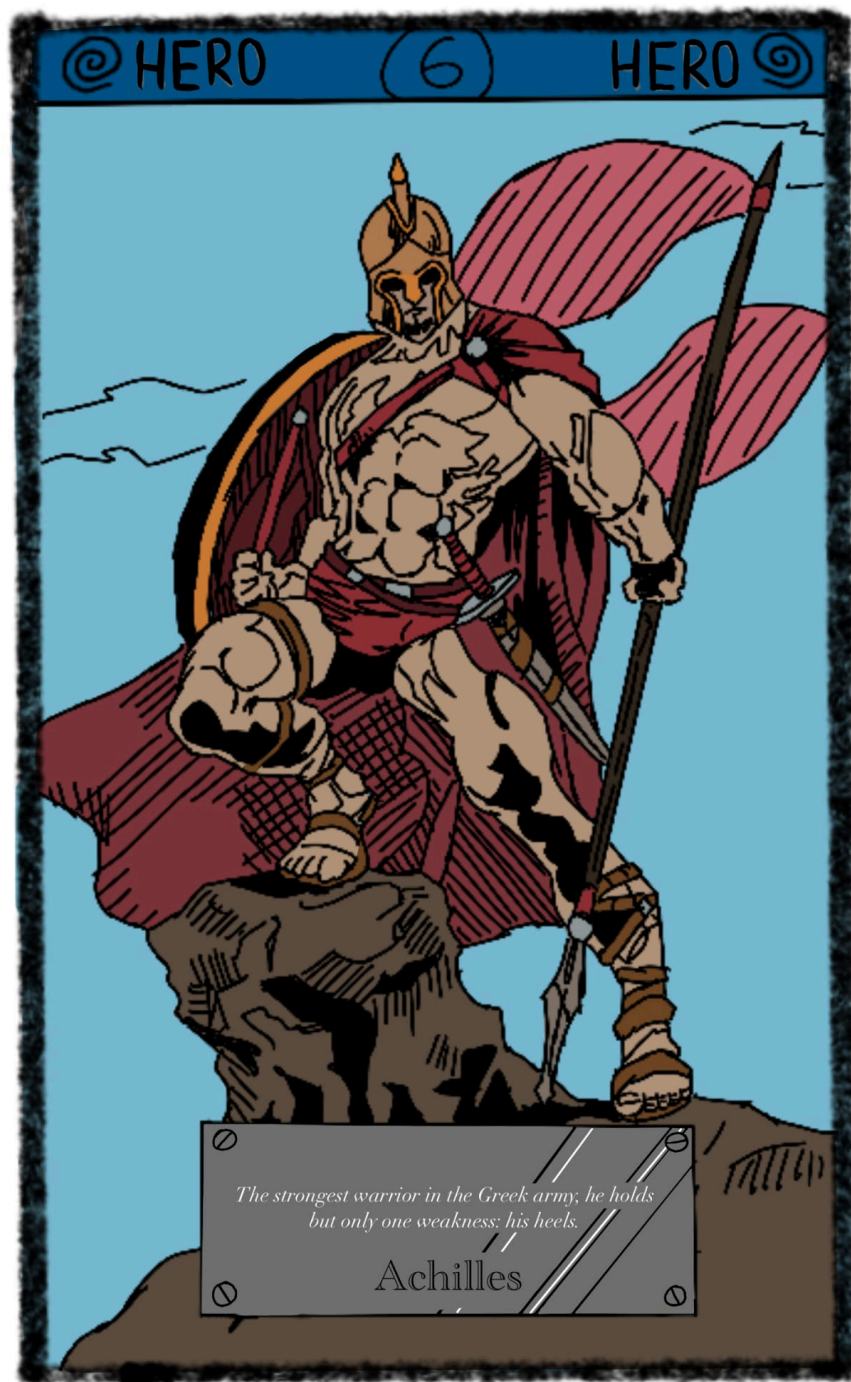
Since the game will be simple in terms of physical pieces, the theme and style will play an important role in player engagement. As shown in the inspiration, we have drawn from the vast Greek Mythos and the unique events and characters that feature. Characters like Hercules and Achilles are used as 'Hero' cards, as they are referred to in their respective stories to be heroes of some kind. In the same vein, the event cards will take direct inspiration from points of interest in the Greek Myth timeline; A Hydra Attack, Taming the Pegasus, et cetera. While we will talk about the colours soon, the theme of wealth relating to the overall look and feel of the cards will be prominent. The cards will be lined with the colour gold, and green will be used extensively, pertaining to the incredible decadence that the Ancient Greek Gods were known for.

As the heroes are known for their respective battle or heroic deed, the theme of battle will be present. Various weapons, well known or not, will be used throughout the game, whether that be in the individual hero's art or the buff and curse cards. This theme will add to the feeling of the game, as the player battles to win their prediction.

Style

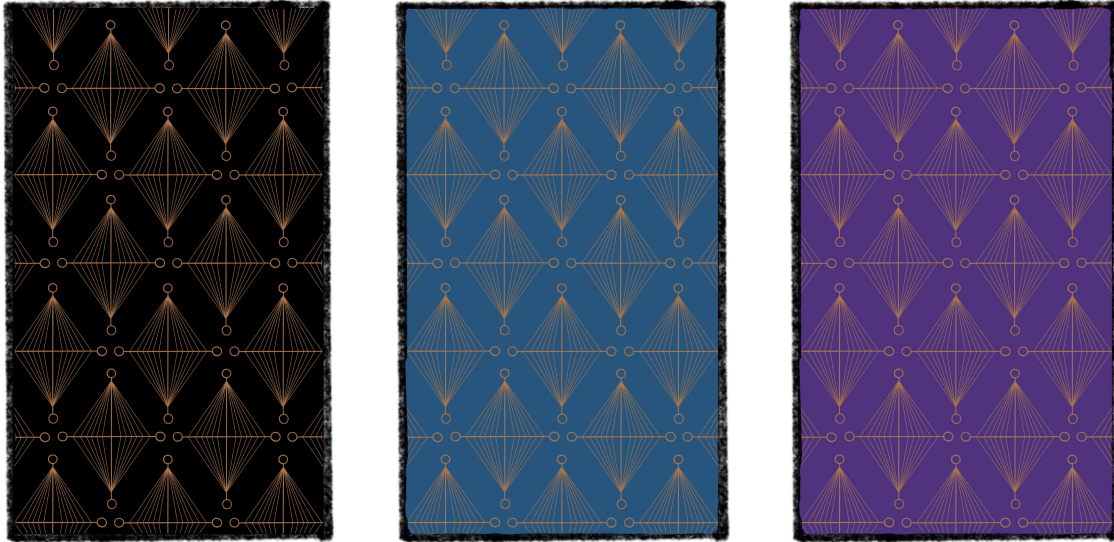
The style will take motifs from Greek Mythology and visualise them. The colours will revolve around the Wealth theme we mentioned as they are related to greed and envy, two important emotions that will be utilised throughout the gameplay. Other than the art, the feel of the card will be important. The game cards will be at least 350gsm (the typical paper thickness mode of measurement) and will have a different front and back. The back of the boon and curse cards will look identical to make sure they can't be distinguished when they are in your hand. Colours on the back of the cards will change based on the type; blue for heroes, purple for events, black for boons and curses.





Here is a draft coloured version of one of the card designs with the description included. We wanted the cards to include at least one of the colours mentioned in the scheme but not limiting it to them as we want them to look different and unique.

These are the example artworks of some of the cards. Their style will include the green and gold colours. The backs will be consistent in their design and style, differing only in colour: Black for Boons and Curses, Blue for Heroes and Purple for Events.



Market Analysis

'Apollo's Gamble's targeted age demographic is those aged 15-25~ as it requires an intermediate level understanding of game rules, coupled with thoughts of strategy and deception. As 'Apollo's Gamble' highlights a 'pick up and play' nature with little starting rules, the game appeals to people who want an entertaining game to quickly play at their own pace. The game is ideal for a group of friends on break as a quick game before getting back to work, or as a party game.

As the game is designed around deception, predicting what other players strategies are and attempting to predict the final outcome, players who are familiar with or enjoy other games such as; Space Alert, Cutthroat Caverns and/or Dungeon Mayhem, will likely enjoy 'Apollo's Gamble' due not only to its quick pick up and play nature but also due to its aesthetic based in Greek Mythology, which is not often seen in the current board and card game market.

References

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Covert, C. *Cutthroat Caverns*. IELLO, Smirk & Dagger Games, 2007. Board Game.

Robbins, M. *Uno*. Mattel, 1992. Card Game.

Apollo's Gamble Box Art sourced from;

<https://twitter.com/yliade2/status/1193874867730472960?s=12>